

Castles

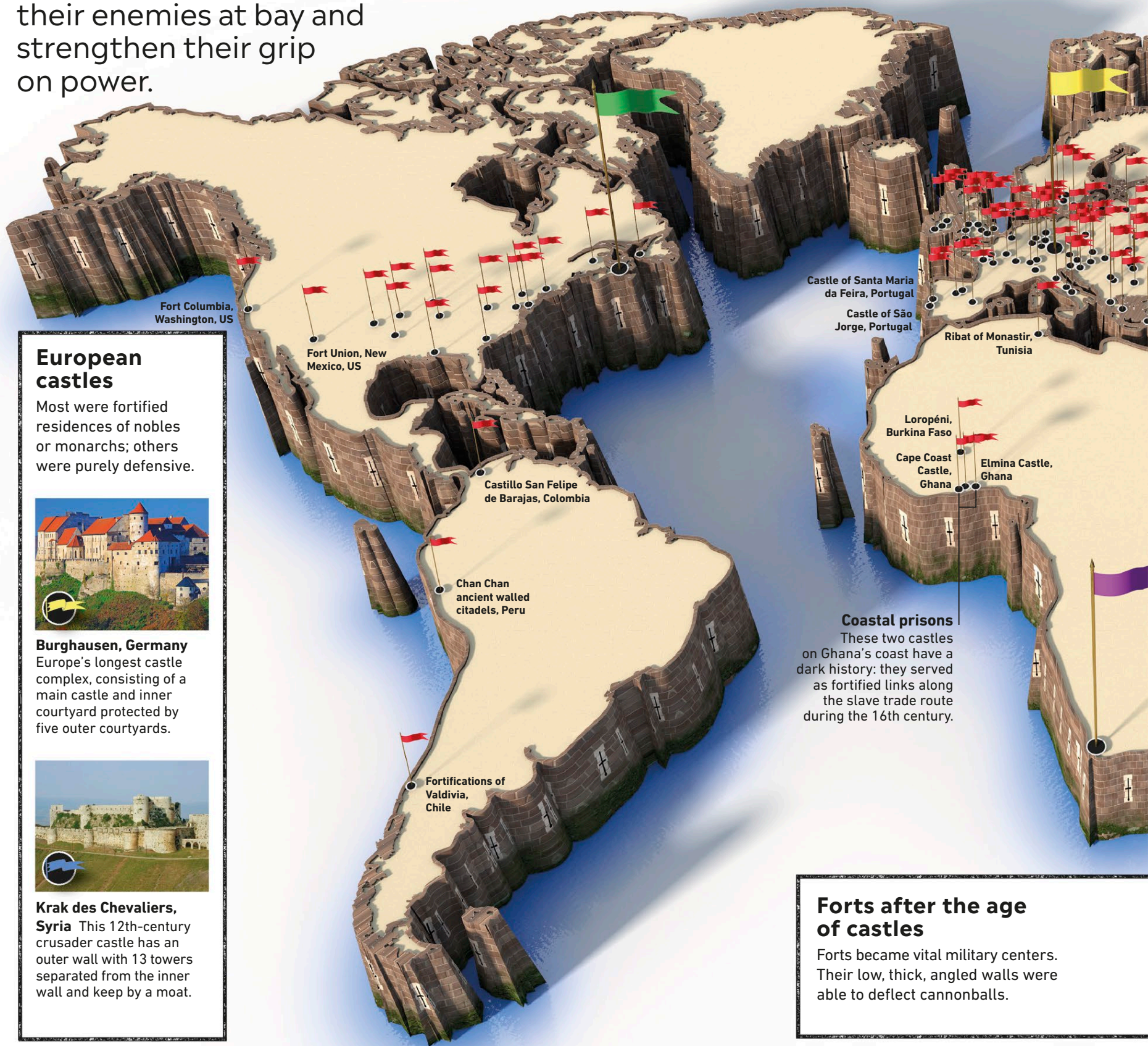
From castles and forts to walled cities, rulers and nations throughout history have tried to build impregnable structures to keep their enemies at bay and strengthen their grip on power.

KEY

Flags pinpoint some of the world's most impressive fortifications.



Selected castles, forts, citadels, and fortified cities



European castles

Most were fortified residences of nobles or monarchs; others were purely defensive.



Burghausen, Germany

Europe's longest castle complex, consisting of a main castle and inner courtyard protected by five outer courtyards.



Krak des Chevaliers, Syria

This 12th-century crusader castle has an outer wall with 13 towers separated from the inner wall and kept by a moat.

Castle of Santa Maria da Feira, Portugal

Castle of São Jorge, Portugal

Ribat of Monastir, Tunisia

Loropéni, Burkina Faso

Cape Coast Castle, Ghana

Elmina Castle, Ghana

Castillo San Felipe de Barajas, Colombia

Chan Chan ancient walled citadels, Peru

Fortifications of Valdivia, Chile

Coastal prisons

These two castles on Ghana's coast have a dark history: they served as fortified links along the slave trade route during the 16th century.

Forts after the age of castles

Forts became vital military centers. Their low, thick, angled walls were able to deflect cannonballs.